

4.1 Poetry across periods

Paper 4 Pre- and Post-1900 Poetry and Prose · 2026 examination · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

Period labels can inform genre and context but should never replace close reading. Compare voice, form, images and attitudes on a shared issue, making space for differences within an era. A text's date matters when a specific convention or social relation helps interpret a wording; do not invent an author's intention.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

Two poems about work might share a repeated verb but use different rhythm: one ordered and regular, the other disrupted. Explain how form supports each treatment before drawing a contextual conclusion.

Original practice stimulus

A. At six the bells divide the day;
The roofs release the morning's grey.
I walk beneath a measured sky
And count the hours passing by.
B. No bell could hold the hours apart;
The rain had moved across the square.
We stayed until the market closed
And found the afternoon still there.

These short poems were written for this guide. Neither carries a historical date. The regular pairings in A and the loosened time in B allow a comparison of rhythm, perspective and the speakers' attitudes to measured time without requiring invented background.

Extended response

Compose your response in the space provided and support your interpretation with evidence.

1 Original lines A: "At six the bells divide the day." B: "No bell could hold the hours
apart." Compare the speakers' attitudes to measured time. [25]

Check: relevant evidence · coherent argument · accurate and deliberate language

Answers and explanation

Question 1 [25 marks]

A strong response contrasts division/order in A with defiance or flux in B, explains modal “could,” and resists attributing centuries or named writers from these lines alone. For set texts add accurate context and close textual support.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or calculation error; then retry without looking at the solution.

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<https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/636097-2024-2026-syllabus.pdf>

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